

Title

Characterizing Rehabilitation Intensity in Stroke Recovery: A Cross-Site Canadian Practice Survey

Abstract

Purpose: Current clinical guidelines recommend high-intensity stepping activities and cardiovascular exercise during inpatient stroke rehabilitation, yet implementation and adherence to these targets remain unclear. This descriptive protocol aims to characterize rehabilitation intensity during typical physical therapy sessions across multiple Canadian rehabilitation facilities. **Methods:** We will conduct a cross-sectional assessment of rehabilitation sessions at a sample of Canadian inpatient stroke rehabilitation units. **Inclusion criteria** are medically stable stroke survivors admitted for inpatient rehabilitation, minimum functional capacity to ambulate with assistance of one person. Participants will be assessed during one rehabilitation session using objective devices: wrist-worn monitors will quantify aerobic exercise time (defined as exercise exceeding 40% heart rate reserve), and ankle-worn step counters will record step numbers. We will describe the distribution of aerobic minutes and step counts, their correlation with participant characteristics, and documentation of guideline-adherent exercise intensities. Data will be analyzed using descriptive statistics and correlation methods. This observational study will provide baseline data on current rehabilitation practice patterns.